

# Courbet, Millet and Daumier

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**G**ustave Courbet (1819–77) originally used the term Realism to describe his own work, and later issued a manifesto on the subject. Breaking with artistic conventions by painting scenes of ordinary people on the vast canvases that the Académie regarded as only suitable for history painting (effectively making the poor as important as the rich), his radical beliefs and style were initially ridiculed, but later hailed by avant-garde artists as revolutionary and influential. Jean-François Millet (1814–75), a founder of the Barbizon School, also began painting the hardships of peasant life, demonstrating his strong feelings about social injustice. Influenced by Chardin and 17th-century Dutch art, his work in turn influenced others including Jozef Israëls (1824–1911) and Van Gogh.

Close analysis of social problems can also be seen in the paintings, lithographs and sculptures of Honoré Daumier (1808–79), many of which were published in satirical political journals. Although he was best known for his critical caricatures, his expressive, direct and powerful painting style epitomized Realism's aims.



Millet, *The Angelus*, 1857–9